

Compact Digital Cameras

Face detection, low-light shooting mode, red-eye reduction and panorama view mode—these are just a few of the many features that today's ergonomically designed compact digital cameras pack in at affordable prices

PRIY PANDIT

Be it a wedding party or a jam-packed rock show, there are special moments that we want to capture and share with everyone. Latest smartphones with high-megapixel cameras seem competent enough for the job. But if you want quality photos and are meticulous about shooting in low light, or with minimal shutter lag or rich optical zoom, you need a digital camera for sure.

Like budget mobile phones, you can get a feature-rich compact digital camera, commonly known as a point-and-shoot camera, without burning a hole in your pocket.

"The Indian camera market, which sells 2.5 million units annually, is growing rapidly. Currently, the market for compact digital cameras is mainly dominated by a handful of players and a cut-throat competition exists amongst these players," says K. Tanaka, managing director, Fujifilm India.

Due to the rising competition, compact digital cameras are available

for as less as around Rs 3000. Before you seal the deal at a neighbourhood consumer electronics store or at an online retail site, go through these pointers.

Megapixel

It is not advisable to buy a smartphone only for its camera. The Nokia N8, for

megapixel count accordingly.

Zoom (optical and digital)

Digital cameras are best put to test when capturing subjects at a long or moderate distance. These feature two types of zoom, optical and digital. Like with binoculars, optical zoom, also called true zoom, uses the optical system of the camera to bring the subject closer. On the other hand, digital zoom uses an internal software application rather than the lens of the camera to expand a small portion of the image. Optical zoom does not degrade the quality of the image, whereas digital zoom causes observable loss in it.



Samsung PL20

example, priced at Rs 19,000 features a 12MP camera. Unless you buy an obsolete make, most point-and-shoot cameras available in the market carry 10 MP or higher resolution.

The resolution of a digital camera determines the quality of the image. It is actually a criterion of image sharpness indicated by the number of pixels in that image. The more the pixels in an image, the sharper and detailed it would be. If you plan to do a lot of image cropping or wish to enlarge prints, choose the

As Sajjan Kumar, vice president-imaging, Nikon India, puts it, "Though digital zoom offers a longer zoom range, the image quality isn't as good as optical zoom. If you choose a camera with a long zoom lens, generally anything over 5x, make sure it also offers optical image stabilisation to help minimise blurry photos from camera shake."

Optical zoom between 4x and 6x has become the standard for most point-and-shoot cameras available in the market and fits the bill for moderate usage.

Memory

Digital cameras come with two kinds of memory, in-built and removable.



Fujifilm FinePix C20